

22. Trace the history of child-rights in India.  
[Ans: 1:03:2]
23. Explain the various Non-Governmental organisations working for child-rights in Tamilnadu and India. [Ans: 1:04:1 + 1:04:2]
24. Discuss the historic treatment of children in India.  
[Ans: 1:05 + 1:05:1 to the end of 1:05:3]
25. Explain the understanding obtained on child-rights from the perspective of affected people.  
[Ans: 1:06]
26. Discuss any ten important Articles related to child rights stated in the "United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child". [Ans: 1:08 + In 1:08:1 Articles 19, 20, 23, 24, 28, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 38, 40]
27. What are 'MDGs'? List the eight MDGs with their targets. [Ans: 1:09:1 + 1:09:2]
28. Discuss the various Sustainable Development Goals as adopted by U.N. General Assembly in 2015. [Ans: 1:09:2 + 1:09:2:01 + 1:09:2:02]
29. Discuss the mutual relationship between child rights and Sustainable Development Goals.  
[Ans: 1:10]

## UNIT - II

### VIOLENCE AGAINST CHILDREN

#### 2:00 Introduction

Violence against children occurs when perpetrators such as relatives, teachers, community members, peers or strangers violate a child's physical, sexual or emotional well-being. Violence against children is a global crisis and a human rights violation. Victims exist in every country. Globally, it is estimated that upto 1 billion children aged 2-17 years, have experienced physical, sexual or emotional violence or neglect in the past year.

In this unit, Violence Against Children: Various forms and trends in Tamil Nadu, Abuse of Trust, Discrimination, Drug dependency among children, Online abuse, Suicidal tendency among children, Intersectionality, Consequences of impact of violence on children and Factors leading to vulnerability of children in Tamil Nadu and root causes, are taken up for a detailed discussion.

#### 2:01 Violence Against Children

Violence against children (VAC), includes all forms of violence involving mal-treatment (physical,

sexual and psychological / emotional violence), bullying (including cyber-bullying), child trafficking, forced labour, child soldiering, intimate partner violence and domestic violence against people under 18 years old, whether perpetrated by parents or other caregivers, such as relatives, peers, romantic partners, teachers, community members or strangers. According to the World Health Organisation, 1 in 2 children under 18 years, suffer from some form of violence – physical, sexual, or emotional violence or neglect every year.

Experiencing violence in childhood impacts lifelong health and well-being. Target 16.2 of the 2030 **Agenda for Sustainable Development** is to "end abuse, exploitation, trafficking and all forms of violence against, and torture of children."

Violence against children is a global crisis and a human rights violation. Poverty exacerbates the risk of violence, abuse and exploitation of children. Children who lack basic needs are often left vulnerable, fending for themselves. Perpetrators of violence prey on these marginalized children.

## 2:01:1 Various Forms of Violence Against Children and Trends in Tamil Nadu

Most violence against children involves at least one of the following six main types of interpersonal violence that tend to occur at different stages in a child's development.

- **Mal-treatment** (including violent punishment) involves physical, sexual and psychological/emotional violence; and neglect of infants, children and adolescents by parents, caregivers and other authority figures, most often in the home but also in settings such as schools and orphanages.
- **Bullying** (including cyber-bullying) is unwanted aggressive behaviour by another child or group of children who are neither siblings nor in a romantic relationship with the victim. It involves repeated physical, psychological or social harm, and often takes place in schools and other settings where children gather, and online.
- **Intimate partner violence** (or domestic violence) involves physical, sexual and emotional violence by an intimate partner or ex-partner.



Although males can also be victims, intimate partner violence disproportionately affects females. It commonly occurs against girls within child marriages and early/forced marriages. Among romantically involved but unmarried adolescents, it is sometimes called “**dating violence**”.

- **Sexual violence** includes non-consensual completed or attempted sexual contact and acts of a sexual nature not involving contact (such as voyeurism or sexual harassment); acts of sexual trafficking committed against someone who is unable to consent or refuse; and online exploitation.
- **Emotional or psychological violence** includes restricting a child's movements, denigration, ridicule, threats and intimidation, discrimination, rejection and other non-physical forms of hostile treatment.
- **Domestic Violence:** Violence can also occur within a child's family. Abuse of substances like alcohol and drug use may manifest as physical and psychological aggression towards those they are closest to, including children.

- Youth violence is concentrated among children and young adults aged 10–29 years, occurs most often in community settings between acquaintances and strangers, includes bullying and physical assault with or without weapons (such as guns and knives), and may involve gang violence.

When directed against girls or boys because of their biological sex or gender identity, any of these types of violence can also constitute gender-based violence.

## 2:02 Child Abuse and Abuse of Trust

### 2:02:1 Child Abuse

Child abuse is when any one under the age of 18 is either being harmed or not properly looked after. There are four main categories of child abuse: (i) Physical abuse, (ii) emotional abuse, (iii) sexual abuse and (iv) neglect.

**Physical abuse** is when someone hurts a child or young person physically on purpose.

**Eg:** Hitting, slapping, shaking or throwing; burning or scalding; drowning, suffocating or

choking, pushing or kicking, using physical force to discipline etc.

**Emotional abuse** happens in many different ways. It can affect how a person or child feels about themselves, or how they fit in with friends, at school or where they live in.

**Eg:** Being made to feel inadequate, worthless or unloved; being unfairly blamed; being bullied, including over the internet (Cyber-bullying); being made to feel frightened or in danger; made to witness the abuse of others such as **domestic abuse**.

**Sexual abuse** is when a child is enticed or forced to take part in sexual activities. This kind of abuse does not always involve a high level of violence and the child may or may not be aware of what is happening. Sexual abuse may be committed by adult men and women, or by other children.

**Eg:** Causing or inciting a child to watch or engage in sexual activities; encouraging a child to behave in sexually inappropriate ways; involving a child in looking at sexual images or videos; grooming

a child in preparation for abuse (including via the internet).

**Neglect:** Neglect is when a child or young person's basic needs [such as adequate food, clothing and shelter; protection from physical and emotional harm or danger; adequate supervision (being left at home alone); access to appropriate medical care] are persistently not being met by their parents or guardian.

## 2:02:2 Abuse of Trust or Dominant Position

Abuse of children takes many forms. It can be physical, emotional, sexual or neglect. It happens in all countries and in any settings — in a child's home, community, school, online etc. In some parts of the world, including India, 'Violent discipline' i.e. disciplining the child through physical punishment, is socially accepted and common. And for many girls and boys, abuse takes place at the hands of the people they trust — their parents or care-givers, teachers, peers and neighbours.

In order for an abuse of trust to make an offence more serious, the relationship between the



offender and victim(s) must be one that would give rise to the offender having a significant level of responsibility towards the victim(s) on which the victim(s) would be entitled to rely.

Abuse of trust may occur in many factual situations. Examples may include relationships such as teacher and pupil, parent and child, professional adviser and client, or carer (whether paid or unpaid) and dependant. It may also include ad hoc situations such as a late-night taxi driver and a lone passenger. It would not generally include familial relationship without a significant level of responsibility.

Where an offender has been given an inappropriate level of responsibility, abuse of trust is unlikely to apply. A close examination of the facts is necessary and a clean justification should be given if abuse of trust is to be found.

## 2:03 Discrimination

### 2:03:1 Meaning of Discrimination

Discrimination is the process of making unfair or prejudicial distinctions between people based on the groups, classes, or other categories to which

they belong or are perceived to belong, such as race, gender, age, religion, physical attractiveness or sexual orientation. Discrimination typically leads to groups being unfairly treated on the basis of perceived statuses based on ethnic, racial, gender or religious categories. It involves depriving members of one group, of opportunities or privileges that are available to members of another group.

The United Nations stance on discrimination includes the statement: **"Discriminatory behaviours take many forms, but they all involve some form of exclusion or rejection"**. The United Nations Human Rights Council and other international bodies work towards helping ending discrimination.

### 2:03:2 What Drives Discrimination?

At the heart of all forms of discrimination is prejudice based on concepts of identity and the need to identify with a certain group. This can lead to division, hatred and even the dehumanization of other people because they have a different identity.

In many parts of the world, the politics of blame and fear is on the rise. Intolerance, hatred

and discrimination is causing an ever-widening rift in societies. The politics of fear is driving people apart, as leaders peddle toxic rhetoric, blaming certain groups of people for social or economic problems.

Some governments try to reinforce their power and status quo by openly justifying discrimination in the name of morality, religion or ideology. Discrimination can be cemented in national law, even when it breaks the international law — for example, the criminalization of abortion which denies women, girls and pregnant people the health services only they need. Certain groups even be viewed by the authorities as more likely to be criminal simply for who they are, such as being poor, indigenous or black.

## 2:03:3 Some Key Forms of Discrimination

### i) Racism

Racism affects virtually every country in the world. It systematically denies people their full human rights just because of their colour, race, ethnicity, descent (including caste) or national origin. Racism unchecked can fuel large-scale atrocities such as the 1994 genocide in Rwanda.

and more recently, apartheid and ethnic cleansing of the Rohingya people in Myanmar.

### ii) Religion and Caste

People may be discriminated based on religion. In most of the Muslim countries, non-muslims do not enjoy the same rights and privileges as those of Muslims. In India and other countries, even within the same religion there are numerous castes which are treated differently. According to **UNICEF** and **Human Rights Watch**, caste discrimination affects an estimated 250 million people worldwide and is mainly in parts of Asia (India, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Nepal, Japan) and Africa. As of 2011, there were 200 million **Dalits or Scheduled Castes** (formerly known as “untouchables”) in India.

### iii) Gender Discrimination

In many countries, in all regions of the world, laws, policies, customs and beliefs exist, that deny women and girls their rights. By law, women can not dress as they like (Saudi Arabia, Iran) or work at night (Madagascar) or take out a loan without their husband's signature (Equatorial Guinea). In many countries discriminatory laws



place limits on a woman's right to divorce, own property, exercise control over her own body and enjoy protection from harassment.

#### iv) Gender Orientation

Everywhere in the world, people face discrimination because of who they love, who they are attracted to and who they are. Lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender and intersex (LGBTI) people risk being unfairly treated in all areas of their lives, whether it is education, employment, housing or access to health care and they may face harassment and violence.

#### v) Age Discrimination

**Ageism** or age discrimination is discrimination and stereotyping based on the grounds of someone's age. It is a set of beliefs, norms and values which used to justify discrimination or subordination based on a person's age. Ageism is most often directed toward elderly people, or adolescents and children.

#### vi) Disability

Discrimination against people with disabilities in favour of people who are non-disabled, is called

**disablism.** Disability discrimination, which treats non-disabled individuals as the standard of 'normal living', results in public and private places and services, educational settings and social services that are built to serve 'standard' people, thereby excluding those with various disabilities.

#### vii) Discrimination against Non-nationals

Discrimination against non-nationals is frequently based on racism or notions of superiority, and is often fuelled by politicians looking for scapegoats for social or economic problems in a country.

Since 2008, **South Africa** has experienced several outbreaks of violence against refugees, asylum seekers and migrants from other African countries, including killings and looting or burning of shops and businesses. Discrimination has also been a feature of the response to refugees and asylum seekers in other parts of the world. Many people in countries receiving refugees and asylum seekers, view the situation as a crisis with leaders of political parties exploiting these fears by promising to enact abusive and unlawful policies.

### viii) Reverse Discrimination

Reverse discrimination is the discrimination against members of dominant or majority group, in favour of members of minority or historically disadvantaged group. Groups may be defined in terms of disability, ethnicity, family status, gender identity, nationality, race, religion, caste, sex and gender orientation etc. In some countries, countervailing measures such as reserved quotas have been used to redress the balance in favour of those who are believed to be current or past victims of discrimination. These attempts have often been met with controversy, and sometimes been called reverse discrimination.

Reverse discrimination can be defined as the unequal treatment of members of the majority groups, resulting from preferential policies, as in college admissions or employment, intended to remedy earlier discrimination against minorities.

### ix) Childism : Prejudice and Discrimination against Children

Children experience discrimination both as group and as individuals on various grounds, such

as their age, national, ethnic or social origin, gender, language, religion, disability, gender orientation or other status.

Some acts are only considered criminal, if they are committed by someone aged under 18. This just not include things such as drinking alcohol. In some US states, for example, it is illegal for Children to run away from home or even to repeatedly disobey parental authority. This behaviour is called 'incurrigibility'. If a child is decided to be incurrigible by a court, the sanctions he/she can receive include detention in a juvenile facility. In over 130 countries in the world, children lack full protection against corporal punishment. In England, children can lawfully be smacked by parents if the smack can be considered "reasonable punishment". This kind of unequal treatment is an example of childism.

The Convention on the Rights of the Child enshrines the principle of non-discrimination. All children should be treated, protected, and cared for in the same manner. However, many children are victims of discrimination.



The rights of children who are considered part of a minority, are often violated, notably by acts of discrimination, racism, and non-recognition. Children of minorities face many barriers to enjoy and exercise their rights.

Around the world, there are 150 million children suffering from a disability, 80% of whom are living in developing countries. Most often, they do not have access to appropriate care and are victims of discrimination.

In many countries, girls are the first victims when children's human rights are violated and they often suffer double discrimination: for their age and for their gender.

## 2:04 Drug Dependency among Children

**Substance dependence, also known as drug dependence,** is a biopsychological situation whereby an individual's functionality is dependent on the necessitated reconsumption of a psychoactive substance because of an adaptive state that has developed within the individual from psychoactive substance consumption that results in the experience of withdrawal that necessitates the reconsumption of the drug—**Wikipedia.**

The use of psychoactive substances get developed in persons following the **Jellineck Curve**, which describes the 4 stages as (i) occasional use, (ii) dependency, (iii) disorder and (iv) need rehabilitation.

Drug dependance is a chronic progressive disease characterised by significant impairment that is directly associated with persistent and excessive use of psychotic substances. Impairment may involve physiological, psychological or social dysfunction.

**The incidence of drug abuse among children and adolescents is higher than the general population.** This may be because youth is a time for experimentation and identity-forming. Many street children use cheap drugs to cope with the daily cycles of sexual, physical and mental abuse or as recreation to escape a life of poverty. **Heroin, Opium, Alcohol, Cannabis and Propoxyphene are the five most common drugs being abused by children in India.** Children affected by substance abuse are considered as children in need of care and protection under the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015.

The use of certain drugs such as whitener, alcohol, tobacco, hard and soft drugs is especially widespread among street children, working children and trafficked children but there is currently lack of reliable data on drug abuse amongst children.

### **2:04:1 Predictive Risk Factors**

Drug dependancy or drug addiction develops from a complex interplay between the individual, the agent (drugs and alcohol), and the environment. The initiation of first drug use is determined by interactions between social, cognitive, cultural, attitudinal, personality and development factors. The earliest influences to smoke, drink alcohol, or use narcotic substances may come from the family. Factors that are related to drug use during adolescence include poor self-image, low religiosity, poor school performance, parental rejection, family dysfunction, abuse, under or over-controlling by parents, and divorce. Among the environmental factors, free availability and easy access to drugs, neighbourhood disadvantage (i.e. living in slums, shelterless and street children), early peer group pressure play a pivotal role in

the initiation of tobacco, alcohol and drug usage. Biological children of alcohol-dependent parents have an increased risk of developing alcoholism.

Girls seem to be more influenced by environmental factors in the home. Unkempt, crowded, noisy, disorderly condition where there is little emphasis on conventions and religion are very potent predictive factors of later drug use in girls.

### **2:04:2 Effects of Alcohol and other Drugs on Children**

Researches reveal drug dependence in children leads to the development of conduct disorder, oppositional defiant disorder and attention-deficit / hyperactivity disorder (ADHD). These disorders may initially present with relatively mild behaviour problems and progress to severe symptoms such as stealing, aggression, and using heavy dosage of narcotic substances.

Temperamental difficulties may exacerbate childhood troublesome behaviour and result in an insecure attachment with the child's primary caregiver. ADHD in childhood impart a higher risk



of later development of adult alcoholism and substance use.

The direct and indirect effects of alcohol and other drugs on children lead to many adverse health and safety risks for the child, family, and community. Alcohol and other drug use in the adolescent population carries a higher risk for school under-achievement, delinquency, teenage pregnancy and depression. Illicit drug use is associated with an increased risk of human immunodeficiency virus (HIV).

### 2:04:3 Protective Factors

Protective factors are characteristics within the individual, the family and the environment that advance one's ability to resist adverse outcomes. Protective for the pediatric population include growing up in nurturing home with open communication with parents and positive parental support. Teacher commitment to didactics and maintenance of low dissension are also protective.

Positive self-esteem, self-control, assertiveness, social competence, and good academic achievement all promote resistance to drug use.

In addition, regular visit to places of worship like temple, church etc. and a sense of morality have been shown to be protective against drug use.

Protective factors instil in the individual resiliency. **Resiliency is the capacity of an individual to overcome a negative set of life circumstances.** Adolescent resiliency is associated with high intelligence, low novelty-seeking behaviours, and avoidance of friendships with delinquent peers.

Sensitization and awareness programmes about drug abuse in schools or for children out of school, go a long way in the prevention of the use of narcotic substances by children.

### 2:04:4 Indian Scenario

The problem in India is that there are no sensitization programmes about drug abuse in schools or for children out of school. India does not have a substance abuse policy. There is also a high incidence of charging children under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985. Children who at times have no access to high quality drugs will use volatile

substances easily found in corner stores such as cough syrups, pain relief ointments, glue, paint, gasoline and cleaning fluids. There are very few or no health centers that deal with child substance abuse problems, especially in the rural areas. The use of tobacco is another major concern amongst children. In India 20 million children a year and nearly 55,000 children a day are drawn into tobacco addiction. The number is shocking when compared to the 3000 a day new child smokers in the U.S.

## 2:05 Online Abuse

In the digital age, children are exposed to new threats. Online interactions are not always accompanied by the traditional protections placed around children. In addition to the usual means by which sexual abuse of children is perpetrated, children now face risks of sexual abuse that is technologically facilitated. **Online child abuse is a unique form of child abuse due to its virtual, distance and anonymous in nature. Such abuse may not happen face-to-face nor does it necessarily require physical contact.** However online abuse can result in negative face-to-face

consequences in the form of statutory rape, forcible sexual assault, harassment etc. Some of the online abuses are:

**1. Cyber Bullying :** Cyber bullying is when a person or group of people hurt, embarrass, humiliate or intimidate a child over digital devices like cell phones, computers, laptops and tablets. It can occur through text messages, apps, social media, forums or gaming sites, where people can view, participate in or share content. Children who are bullied in schools are most likely to get bullied in the online world.

Some common examples of cyber bullying are:

- i) Posting comments about some one that is mean, hurtful and humiliating. Such statements are called **trolls**.
- ii) Sending, posting, or sharing embarrassing, false, or mean content about a child.
- iii) Threatening a child to make his/her personal information or pictures and videos, publicly available.
- iv) Taking unflattering pictures of a child offline and spreading them online.



- v) Stealing a child's account information to hack his/her accounts and send damaging messages.

**2. Online Grooming:** Grooming has been an age-old tactic of sexually exploiting children, wherein an adult befriends a child and builds trust to engage in sexual acts. In an offline setup, the groomers are usually known to the child's family and easy to spot, whereas online grooming is far more scary.

Online groomers can be a known adult, a stranger who impersonates someone else or an adult who poses as a person of influence with the intent to facilitate online sexual contact. Online grooming can happen on sites and apps where young children are most active. Groomers may send friend requests through social media or strike conversations on online forums and game sites.

Groomers develop an emotional connection with the child by being an encouragement, talking about similar interests, sending gifts, and flirtatious messages. Once they realize they have the child's trust, they steer sexual conversations, send intimate pictures of themselves, ask the child to send sexual photos and videos, or perform

sexual acts over live streaming. The children sometimes may not realize exploitation and think of online groomers as their friends or girl friends. They may feel love, loyalty even admiration for their groom. After winning the trust of the children, groomers may invite them for a physical meet, making things more dangerous and worse, leading to human trafficking, rape and even death.

**3. Online Sexual Abuse:** Online sexual abuse is when a person manipulates and force a child to engage in a sexual activity. It can be any type of sexual harassment, exploitation or abuse that takes place through digital mediums. Sending unwanted nude photographs to child via chat and through live streaming, engaging a child in a sexual chat by force and blackmailing a child to share their personal images and perform sexual acts through live streaming, are some examples for online sexual abuse.

Abusers use the vulnerability of children to induce fear and anxiety in their minds. They threaten the children to do what they want by saying they will release the sexual photos or videos, if they do not oblige. Often, abuse starts

online and then takes place in person. The impact of online child abuse on the emotion and psychology of the child is the same as of in person.

To protect children from online abuse, the following precautionary steps can be taken.

- Parents should encourage their children talk to them about how they use the internet and show to them what they do and make sure that they come to them for advice.
- Have an agreement in place and set boundaries for their internet use, such as when and where they can use their devices and for how long.
- Check age ratings that come with games, apps, films and social networks to confirm whether they are suitable.
- Activate parental controls on your home network and all devices including mobile phones and game consoles.
- Safe settings can also be activated on sites such as Google, You Tube.

## 2:06 Suicidal Tendency among Children

Suicidal thoughts do not always lead to suicidal behaviour; but they are a risk factor for

suicidal behaviour. Several factors typically interact before suicidal thoughts become the suicidal behaviour.

**Suicidal behaviour is an action intended to harm oneself and includes suicidal gestures, suicidal attempts and completed suicide. Suicidal ideation is thoughts and plans about suicide.** Suicide attempts are acts of self-harm that could result in death, such as hanging, drowning or taking poison.

Very often there is an underlying mental health disorder and stressful event that triggers the suicidal behaviour. Stressful events include death of loved ones, loss of boy friend or girl friend, a move from familiar surroundings such as the school or neighbourhood or friends, humiliation by family members or friends, being bullied at school, especially for lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) students, failure at school, trouble with law.

However, such stressful events are fairly common among children and rarely lead to suicidal behaviour, if there are no other underlying



problems. The most common underlying problems are the following:

- i) **Depression:** Children or adolescents with depression have feelings of hopelessness and helplessness that limit their ability to consider alternative solutions to immediate problems.
- ii) **Alcohol or substance use disorders:** The use of alcohol or illicit drugs lowers inhibitions against dangerous actions and interferes with anticipation of consequences.
- iii) **Poor impulse control:** Adolescents, particularly those who have a disruptive behavioural disorder such as conduct disorder, may act without thinking.

Children and adolescents attempting suicide are sometimes angry with family members or friends; are unable to tolerate anger, and turn the anger against themselves. Having difficulty in communicating with parents may also contribute to the risk of suicide.

Children with suicidal tendencies can be easily identified by parents and friends. Children and adolescents often confide only in their peers and

express overt thoughts of suicide, such as "I wish I should not have been born" or "I would like to go to sleep and never wake up". Children may express subtle signs, such as social withdrawal, falling grades, or parting with favourite possessions. Family members and friends should take suicide threats or attempts seriously.

The following may help to reduce the risk of suicide:

- i) Getting effective care for mental, physical and substance use disorders.
- ii) Getting support from family and the community.
- iii) Learning ways to peacefully resolve the conflict.
- iv) Limiting media access to suicide-related content.
- v) Having cultural and religious beliefs that discourage suicide.

Suicide prevention programmes can also help. The most effective programmes are those that try to make sure the child has the following:

- ✦ A supportive nurturing environment.
- ✦ Ready access to mental health services.

- ◆ A school or other social setting that promotes respect for individual, racial, and cultural differences.

## 2:07 Intersectionality

**Intersectionality is a sociological analytical framework for understanding how groups' and individuals' social and political identities result in unique combinations of discrimination and privilege.** Examples of these factors include gender, caste, sex, race, ethnicity, class, sexuality, religion, disability, height, age, weight, species and physical appearance. These intersecting and overlapping social identities may be both empowering and oppressing. However, little good-quality quantitative research has been done to support or undermine the practical uses of intersectionality.

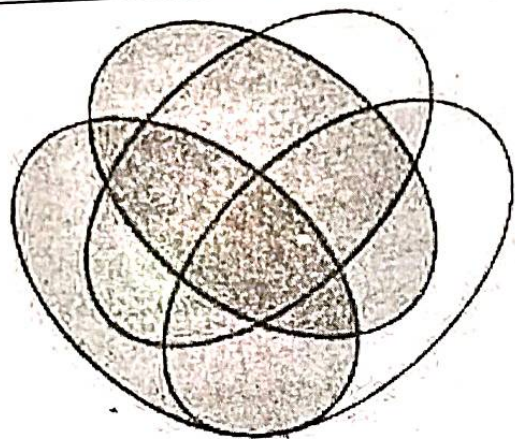
Intersectionality broadens the scope of the first and second waves of feminism, which largely focused on the experiences of women who were white, middle-class and cisgender, to include the different experiences of women of colour, poor women, immigrant women, and other groups.

Intersectional feminism aims to separate itself from white feminism by acknowledging women's differing experiences and identities.

The term intersectionality was coined by **Kimberlé Crenshaw** in 1989. She describes how interlocking systems of power affect those who are most marginalized in society. **Activists and academics use the framework to promote social and political egalitarianism.** Intersectionality opposes analytical systems that treat each axis of oppression in isolation. In this framework, for instance, discrimination against black women cannot be explained as a simple combination of misogyny and racism, but as something more complicated. Intersectionality engages in similar themes as triple oppression, which is the oppression associated with being a poor or immigrant woman of color.

An intersectional analysis considers a collection of factors that affect a social individual in combination rather than considering each factor in isolation. This is illustrated in the following page using a **Venn diagram**.





Intersectionality originated in **critical race studies** and demonstrates a multifaceted connection between race, gender, and other systems that work together to oppress, while also allowing privilege in other areas. Intersectionality is relative because it displays how race, gender, and other components "intersect" to shape the experiences of individuals. **Crenshaw** used intersectionality to denote how race, class, gender and other systems combine to shape the experiences of many, by making room for privilege.

## 2:08 Consequences of Impact of Violence on Children

Violence against children has life long impacts on health and well-being of children, families,

communities, and nations. Violence against children can:

- i) Cause physical and psychological trauma in them.
- ii) Cause harmful mental health impacts like anxiety and depression
- iii) Lead to social ostracism
- iv) Result in death: Homicide, which often involves weapons such as knives and firearms, is among the top four causes of death in adolescents, with boys comprising over 80% of victims and perpetrators.
- v) Lead to severe injuries: For every homicide, there are hundreds of predominantly male victims of youth violence who sustain injuries because of physical fighting and assault. Severe injuries may result in disabilities.
- vi) Impair brain and nervous system development: Exposure to violence at an early age can impair brain development and damage other parts of the nervous system, as well as the endocrine, circulatory, musculo-skeletal, reproductive, respiratory and immune systems, with lifelong consequences. As such, violence

against children can negatively affect cognitive development and results in educational and vocational under-achievement.

- vii) Result in negative coping and health risk behaviours: Children exposed to violence and other adversities are substantially more likely to smoke, misuse alcohol and drugs, and engage in high-risk sexual behaviour. They also have higher rates of anxiety, depression, other mental health problems and suicide.
- viii) Lead to unintended pregnancies, induced abortions, gynaecological problems, and sexually transmitted infections, including HIV.
- ix) Contribute to a wide range of non-communicable diseases as children grow older. The increased risk for cardiovascular disease, cancer, diabetes, and other health conditions is largely due to the negative coping and health risk behaviours associated with violence.
- x) Impact opportunities and future generations: Children exposed to violence and other adversities are more likely to drop out of school, have difficulty in finding and keeping

a job, and are at heightened risk for later victimization and/or perpetration of interpersonal and self-directed violence, by which violence against children can affect the next generation.

## **2:09 Factors Leading to Vulnerability of Children in Tamilnadu and Root Causes**

### **2:09:1 Factors Leading to Vulnerability of Children to Violence**

Violence against children is a multifaceted problem with causes at the individual, close relationship, community and societal levels. Important risk factors are:

#### **(i) Individual level:**

- biological and personal aspects such as sex and age
- lower levels of education
- low income
- having a disability or mental health problems
- identifying as or being identified as lesbian, gay, bisexual or transgender



- harmful use of alcohol and drugs
- a history of exposure to violence.

**(ii) Close-relationship level:**

- lack of emotional bonding between children and parents or caregivers
- poor parenting practices
- family dysfunction and separation
- being associated with delinquent peers
- witnessing violence between parents or caregivers
- early or forced marriage.

**(iii) Community level:**

- poverty
- high population density
- low social cohesion and transient populations
- easy access to alcohol and firearms
- high concentrations of gangs and illicit drug dealing.

**(iv) Society level:**

- social and gender norms that create a climate in which violence is normalized

- health, economic, educational and social policies that maintain economic, gender and social inequalities
- absent or inadequate social protection
- post-conflict situations or natural disaster
- settings with weak governance and poor law enforcement.

## **2:09:2 Root Causes for the Vulnerability of Children to Violence**

Though there are numerable causes for the vulnerability of children to violence, among them, the following four stand out as the root causes that render children vulnerable to violence. They are: (i) Utter poverty, (ii) Lack of parental control and supervision, (iii) Parents' or Caregivers' substance use, (iv) Lack of moral values and religiosity in the general population.

### **(i) Utter Poverty**

Poverty exacerbates the risk for violence and abuse and exploitation of children. Children who lack basic needs and care at home are compelled to go for petty jobs at an early age and thus become vulnerable for exploitation and violence. They are

left to fend for themselves. Perpetrators of violence prey on these marginalized children. They use the child's desperation to their advantage.

## ii) Lack of Parental Control and Supervision

In the present society, parents have very negligible control over their children. In the low and middle income group families both the parents have to go for job, leaving the children at home to fend for themselves and this render them vulnerable to violence from intruders. In the affluent families, children are given unbridled freedom which makes them addicted to online use. They view aggressive and obscene pictures and videos through internet devices including cell phones. This makes them more aggressive and sex-prone, leading to sexual assault and violence including bullying their own peers.

## iii) Parents' / [Carers]' Substance Use

Many parents resort to giving greivous physical punishment as a method of disciplining their children. This especially is true of parents and [carers] indulging in the use of narcotics.

## iv) Lack of Moral values and Religiosity in the General Public

In the present day world everybody goes after getting money and acquiring material comforts at any cost without bothering to adhering moral values. Religions have lost their hold on people and there is no much concern for the moral and ethical values among all sections of the society. People have started believing to live as they wish and not in the way one ought to live. The general degradation of society has stooped so low that we hear now and then that a man of 60 years raped a child of age 5 and father sexually assaulting his own teen age daughter. The urgent need of the hour is the inculcation of moral and ethical values among the people, especially among the children, along with tightening the laws, making child abuse punishable with imprisonment of minimum 20 years.

## Conclusion

In this unit, Violence Against Children: Various forms and trends in Tamil Nadu, Abuse of Trust, Discrimination, Drug dependency among children, Online abuse, Suicidal tendency among children,



